

THE IMPERIAL WORLD

THE ERA OF EUROPEAN COLONIAL EXPANSION ACROSS THE GLOBE

Throughout the 18th and 19th centuries the world witnessed a relentless European drive to control territories all over the globe. Colonies provided not only direct supplies of valuable natural resources, but also a theater of conflict in which Europe's antagonisms were played out.

The Imperial Age saw Spain, Britain, France, Germany, Holland, Portugal, Italy, and to a lesser extent, Denmark and Sweden, scramble for territories. A country could lose colonies in one war, only to reclaim them later through trade in a wider political game. Colonies often started out as trading posts, in places such as India, but through political maneuvering and exercising military might European countries began to take control. People living in the Americas, Africa, India, and

Southeast Asia were often on the receiving end of racial prejudice and political oppression. Economic exploitation of colonial territories and their people also frequently occurred, as raw materials were exported out of the country, and slave labor was used. This situation persisted until after World War II, when many colonies around the world began to demand their independence (see pp.422–23).

EMPIRE BUILDING

In the 18th century, most colonial outposts were located along the world's coastlines, as settlements sprung up where ships stopped off. Trading posts grew into cities, often with European-style architecture to reflect the political changes. Over time, improvements in military power, transportation, and health—tropical diseases killed thousands of Europeans—saw the spread of colonial rule throughout the 19th century. This was especially true for Britain and France. However, Spain, which had begun empire-building earlier and controlled large parts of Latin America at the beginning of the period, had lost almost all of its territories by the 1820s.

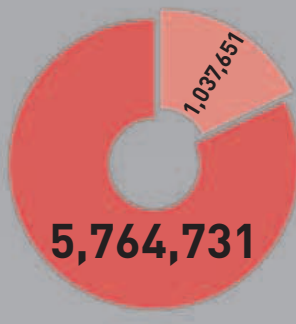
“THE SUN NEVER SETS ON THE BRITISH EMPIRE.”

Popular saying coined during the early 1800s



Expansion

Following the example of Britain and the Netherlands, the small state of Belgium exploited the vast territory of the Congo, which was 76 times larger than Belgium.



Colonial minority

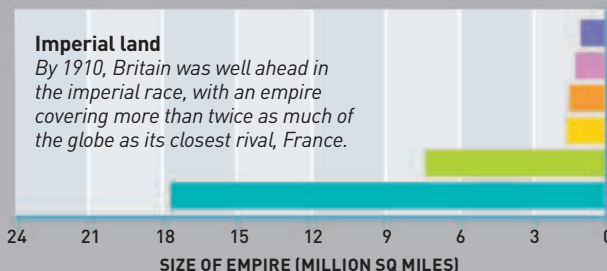
Native Spaniards were in the minority in the Spanish colony of New Spain (Mexico and Central America). In 1810, they made up just under a fifth of the total population.



BRITISH AFRICAN TERRITORIES

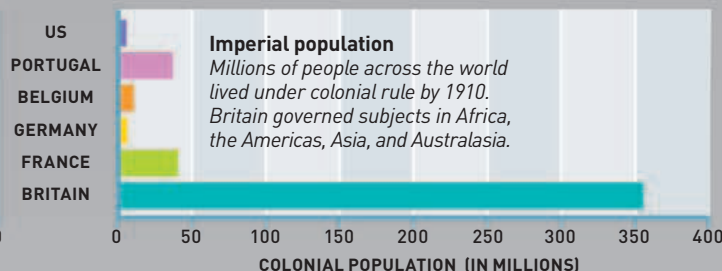
Making tracks

By 1914, the vast expanse of colonial British Africa was spanned by thousands of miles of railroad track, opening the region up to trade and aiding communication between territories.



Imperial land

By 1910, Britain was well ahead in the imperial race, with an empire covering more than twice as much of the globe as its closest rival, France.



Imperial population

Millions of people across the world lived under colonial rule by 1910. Britain governed subjects in Africa, the Americas, Asia, and Australasia.

